

Looks are the first impression of an individual. Male or female, young or old, everybody wants to look great, be admired and adored for the looks. But when the mirror of human body, that is skin, gets affected by the patches, one's confidence takes a nosedive.

The fear of skin disease starts looming large. But then what actually is Psoriasis?

Psoriasis is a chronic, immune-mediated, multifactorial disease. It is a proliferative and inflammatory disease of the skin, which affects people who are genetically predisposed. Psoriasis is one of the most common skin diseases in India. It affects almost 4-5 per cent of the population, having no cure, hence affects the quality of life and self-esteem of the individual.

Psoriasis is a life long disease with flare ups and remission. People with psoriasis have to live with the chronic disease for which there is no known cure. Adequate treatment can, however, relieve the symptoms and help the patient to lead a better life. Many a patients suffer with a feeling that they can never live a normal life like other people. And because of the unsightly nature of the lesions, the patient might feel depressed.

Sometimes the disease is so severe that it occurs all over the body. The most common type of psoriasis is chronic plaque psoriasis. It shows as well-demarcated plaques, which are usually located on the knees, elbows, scalp hair margin or sacrum. The plaques are red and covered with silvery scales. The scales can be itchy and may bleed if scratched.

About half of all people with psoriasis suffer from scalp psoriasis and in about 25% of the patients this is the only area with psoriasis. Scalp psoriasis is also characterised by well-demarcated areas with silvery scaling.

Psoriasis is a physically and mentally debilitating disease. Psoriasis affects the quality of life similar to other chronic conditions such as diabetes, heart disease and hypertension. Another serious impact that has been observed in psoriasis patients is that they tend to get so demotivated in life that they may even feel like attempting suicide. As per a survey, approximately 10% of psoriasis patients develop suicidal thoughts compared to 3% among general patients.

However, such misconceptions and inferiority complex, depression in patients suffering from psoriasis are often borne out of lack of knowledge and also due to

the use of extensive and their

treatments. Both patients and their family members need to know that there are various treatment options available in the market that meet the expectations of the patient and are convenient to use.

Most forms of psoriasis are, however, mild and easily treatable. They are usually localised to few areas of the body.

Topical treatment with drugs specific to those areas can lead to clearing or marked improvement in the skin.

There are several external agents (steroids), which can help a patient with psoriasis. Although topical corticosteroids are effective but long-term usage causes side effects like skin dermal cell proliferation and is safer for long term usage.

thinning, masked infection, rebound phenomenon etc. There is a treatment of calcipotriol available that is a better option and targets the affected area, inhibits epidermal cell proliferation and is safer for long term usage.

Several systemic drugs are useful in severe forms of psoriasis. Systemic retinoid therapy uses a drug called acitretin, but it should be used carefully in women of childbearing age. Methotrexate, an age-old drug, is better in short periods of time, say, three to four months, but liver functions need to be monitored carefully.

Cyclosporine can also be used for short period of time. These drugs can therefore be used sequentially in patients so that the patient is not exposed to any single drug for too long. These yields good results in terms of improving the psoriatic lesions and at the same time protecting the patient from long-term side effects.

Among the topical treatment options, combination of calcipotriol and betamethasone dipropionate (**Daivobet® / Dovobet® / Taclonex®**) is available in the market that has rapid onset of action with fewer side effects along with once daily application. At present they are the most promising drugs to treat chronic plaque psoriasis. This new combination product combines the benefits of a vitamin D3 analogue (calcipotriol) and a corticosteroid (betamethasone dipropionate), therefore provides rapid clearing of skin.

So the future for psoriatic patients is quite good. On the positive side, awareness in the country is fast catching up. There are better and safer treatment options available and a better understanding of the disease. Early treatment and lifestyle modifications also help.

Psoriasis- A Ray of Hope